

Polymorph

Written by Darshan Jain Goburdhone

Synopsis: An old man on his deathbed reflects on three encounters he had with a strange shape-shifting entity throughout his lifetime.

Characters:

- Paul Walsh
- Helen Walsh
- Joseph Walsh
- David Walsh
- Thomas Walsh
- Sergeant Harper
- Sergeant Wallace
- Sergeant Tamura
- Paul's Father and Mother
- Anna
- The Samurai/The Spectre/Proteus

Plot:

*Scenes shot in **color** will be written in **dark magenta**. The rest will be in **black and white**.*

Prologue

The prologue is a 2D animated sequence.

In a huge and sumptuous room, Cronus moves to his father's bed with a scythe. There, Uranus and Gaea sleep peacefully, unaware of the atrocity that is about to ensue. In furious anger, he grabs Uranus and flings him to the floor. Using the scythe, Cronus castrates his father before slaying him for good. Gaea does not react; she knows very well this was bound to happen.

Cronus throws Uranus' genitals and the scythe into the ocean, which awakens Proteus. Carrying the scythe, the half-man and half-sea serpent god rises to the surface and witnesses the formation of a thunderstorm overhead. He shape-shifts into a seagull and carries the scythe to the clouds. As the weather worsens, Zeus emerges from the storm, carrying with him the same scythe used to murder his grandfather.

Back in his palace, Cronus devours one of his offsprings, scared that his children will grow up and overthrow him. But his reign of terror is about to end. Zeus comes in, with the scythe, and does not think twice before slaying his own father. Bleeding, Cronus crashes to the ground which then turns into one dark and endless abyss. He falls into it and is sent straight to Tartarus where he will spend eternity in darkness and torment.

Part 1 - The Beast

For this part, Paul, 37 years old, is portrayed by the same actor who plays his son, Joseph, in the frame narrative.

In March 1944 during the Pacific War, the Bougainville campaign rages between the US Army and Japanese troops. Corporal Paul Walsh, drunk, frightened and trembling from the horrors witnessed in the battlefield, is offered some comfort by his childhood friend, Sergeant Harper. Their regiment from the 37th Infantry Division is currently guarding Hill 700 from the Japanese Army.

Paul recounts how he enlisted after the Pearl Harbor attack due to his hatred for the Japanese and his convictions to defend his homeland at all cost. But once on the battlefield, his rage and determination quickly turned into fear and terror. He is paralyzed by his thanatophobia and the fear that his experiences here will reawaken a “beast” within him, a **Jungian shadow** that he tried to bury in his adolescence. After gunning down so many enemy soldiers during his time in the Pacific War, he knows it’s only a matter of time before that side of him resurfaces. Having been religious before, he now adopts a more agnostic view, claiming no Gods would allow such horrific deaths and sufferings to smear this otherwise peaceful island. Harper reassures him that God has his plans and thus, nothing occurs without purpose. Shall they die, so be it. Paul retorts that whatever God’s grand scheme may be, they don’t justify the massacres he has witnessed. Paul, however, still believes that there has to be an obscure meaning behind such fruitless violence and it’s this fainting belief that diverts him from atheism.

Harper adopts a Freudian stance on death anxiety: fear of dying cannot exist since the human brain cannot process death. The root causes of this fear stems from the fear of finality, loneliness and uncertainty. For religious people, their thanatophobia is managed through the promise of an afterlife. Harper wonders if thanatophobia might stem from unresolved childhood issues and Paul starts to reflect on his relationship with his father and his hatred for him, which he still feels to this day. As for the “beast” that Paul fears will awaken, Harper hopes Paul will harness it on the battlefield, encouraging him to confront and embrace his shadow rather than suppress it.

Whenever Paul totters on the edge of death amidst battles, he often hallucinates the appearance of a **snake**. One would think his thoughts would dwell on his loved ones or something comforting and reassuring but instead, he is haunted by the confounding image of a snake hissing aggressively at him. In times of respite, he often fantasizes on reuniting with Anna, a girl from his childhood he remains inexplicably fixated on. Harper, having known Paul for most of his life, doesn’t recall her. He asks if Paul, in those dire moments, also thinks of his current girlfriend, Helen. Although he admits he loves her and plans to marry her, he ultimately blames her for his death anxiety. Having dealt with suicidal ideation before, Paul developed a fear of death after starting a relationship with Helen since he now has something to lose, something that made survival matter. Now, every bullet, every explosion and every sight of the enemy are a reminder of how fragile life is and just how easily it can be taken from him.

Just then, a hail of mortar fire blasts their camp to smithereens, sending dirt, debris, and body parts hurtling through the air. Before the ringing in Paul’s ears can fade, a screeching army of Japanese soldiers charges towards

them. A fierce and desperate battle ensues on Hill 700 before the regiment is forced to retreat from the onslaught. On their way down the hill, a thick mist enwrathes the forest. Visibility is slowly dwindling. Bullets whizz past Paul and mortar fire haphazardly blasts holes on the ground, increasing his terror and shaking the foundations of his sanity. Then, through the swirling mist, a ghostly shadow phantasmagorically manifests before Paul, as if formed by the mist itself. It looks like a tall **Samurai** dressed in heavy Ronin armor and carrying a katana. Just as he aims his rifle at it, The Samurai disappears.

Suddenly, a deafening silence settles in. The clouds are so thick that Paul can neither see nor hear his own men. A series of shouts cut through the silence and Paul panickedly pulls a grenade and throws it towards wherever they came from. The shouts go dead and it's silent again. As the mist dissipates, he approaches the detritus left by the explosion and what he sees sends him in a state of utter dread and horror. He witnesses his own men, dead, mutilated and dismembered as a result of his own grenade. Amongst them, Sergeant Harper lies unconscious with a big hole in his chest. Through his damaged rib cage, we can see his lungs still inflating and deflating. In tears, Paul aims his rifle at Harper's head and shoots a bullet straight into his skull, putting him out of his misery.

Traumatized and haunted by the consequences of his fears and recklessness, Paul trudges catatonically to another friendly camp where a counteroffensive is already being planned. He speaks not a word of what he has done and reports back that Harper was killed in action. During the nights, he fails to sleep. The distant sounds of explosions and gunfire are no longer bothering him. Instead, the sight of his friends, dead and mangled because of him, permeates his thoughts. These images are now forever burnt in his mind.

Three days later, US Navy destroyers off the western coast of Bougainville bombard Hill 700 with a relentless barrage of artillery fire. After the deafening explosions, thick black clouds billow from the blast zone whilst Paul and his regiment prepare to recapture the hill. As they initiate the counterattack, light tanks and bombers provide them with fire support but once the terrain becomes too steep, it's all up to the soldiers. His fears are back and his hands are shaking as he anticipates the Japanese response to their attack. But once the battle begins, something has changed. His fears are gone. Fueled solely by the rage displaced from the guilt and self-hatred caused by the grenade incident, he goes on a brutal rampage massacring and obliterating enemy soldiers. With each kill, a strange sadistic sense of satisfaction and even pleasure overwhelms him. By the next day, the 37th Division has successfully recaptured Hill 700 and the Japanese withdraw to the forests. Paul is mildly injured, wounded by non-lethal shots in the shoulders and legs, but the euphoria brought by his killings shrouds any kind of pain.

Four months later, Paul is now under the command of Sergeant Wallace. Wallace is the antithesis of Harper; a cold, ruthless and prideful narcissist who denigrates anyone under his command that shows any signs of fear. Wallace sees fear as weakness and weakness as failure. He has taken a particular dislike for Paul, convinced that his timid nature suggests a weak character. The sergeant commands a scouting mission, searching for remnants of the Japanese army still lurking in the forests. Wallace boasts about his military achievements and carries a chain made of human ears cut off from Japanese soldiers as his personal trophy. He then disparages Harper, calling him a bad leader who got himself killed for being a lousy and frail soldier. He mocks Harper's softness, calling

his death inevitable and even deserved. Paul, enraged by his comments, punches Wallace, who retaliates by violently beating and kicking him until he can barely move. As punishment, he orders Paul to go on a forward scout on his own, without any additional supplies.

Alone and weary, Paul gulps down a hip flask, filled with torpedo juice obtained from a Navy soldier. A mist appears again and for a brief instant, Paul glimpses at The Samurai. Before he can react, the figure dissolves back into the mist. Out in the woods, he stumbles upon a shabby Japanese military outpost which appears to be deserted. The whole place is in horrendous condition, full of makeshift graves and reeking of burnt flesh. Inside a thatched hut, Paul finds the sole survivor of the outpost, Sergeant Tamura, hiding behind a broken machine gun. The soldier is malnourished and famished, looking emaciated and diseased. Tamura glances at Paul but doesn't bother doing anything. Paul is disgusted to find a severed roasted arm in what seems to be an improvised kitchen. He asks whose arm it is and Tamura, feeble and murmuring in broken English, reveals it belongs to one of his friends, one of many who starved to death. Foaming with rage, Paul points his rifle at him and asks how many Americans he killed. Tamura admits to killing a lot of them but his words bear no pride or satisfaction. He immediately proceeds to lambast himself for failing the Emperor and his men. He hates being too much of a coward to commit seppuku and die honorably. Pitying him, Paul lowers his rifle and walks away. For him, Tamura is already dead, a fate the Japanese sergeant has probably already made peace with.

After leaving the outpost, the mist thickens. The visibility is further reduced and a sinister atmosphere builds up. The Samurai appears again, now fully visible. Paul raises his weapon at him, asking him to surrender. The Samurai stands unmoved and displays an unsettling calmness despite facing the muzzle of a gun. He introduces himself as being a warrior from Feudal Japan. Not wanting to deal with any nutjobs, Paul shoots but the bullet flies right through The Samurai without ever touching him. This jolts Paul out of his rage and confidence. The Samurai asks why he didn't punish Tamura but Paul doesn't answer. He fires another shot and again, nothing. Trembling with fear, Paul prepares to dash away but The Samurai calmly repeats his question.

Paul argues that Tamura is already suffering enough, his body wasting away from starvation and having to cannibalize his own men. But The Samurai isn't satisfied. Suffering isn't atonement. He says he and Tamura live by the *Bushido* codes. Tamura broke their fundamental virtues by failing to demonstrate heroic courage and dutifulness. Even when he had the chance to restore his honour, he failed to do so through seppuku. He mentions that one honorable principle of *Bushido* is righteousness: the belief of justice, not from others, but from oneself. The intoxicating thought of punishing Tamura, and making him suffer for Japan's atrocities, gnaws at Paul. He asks The Samurai how he should do it. The answer is simply a duel, the most honorable way of obtaining retribution.

Paul storms away, determined to dismiss The Samurai's words and unwilling to succumb to his lust for vengeance. But on his way to his squadron, his anger festers and becomes too overwhelming. He pivots back to the outpost where he picks up two Gunto swords from the graves of Tamura's deceased men and drags Tamura out of his hut. The sergeant is barely able to hold his sword, too weak and famished. Paul screams for Tamura to fight but he simply cannot. He begs Paul to leave him alone, saying he was conscripted and never wanted to fight

in the Emperor's wars anyway. Paul, veins popping out, won't hear any of it. As Tamura drops his sword to surrender, Paul lunges at him, piercing his stomach and disemboweling him. He twists the blade, pulls it free and plunges it back into Tamura, again and again until all his innards are strewn across the ground.

After regaining his composure, Paul collapses on his knees, his mind now swarmed by torment and revulsion at what he has done. The Samurai appears again and condemns Paul for savagely slaughtering a defenceless man in an unfair duel, a clear violation of *Bushido's* principles. This wasn't justice or honor, this was pure uninhibited vengeance. Paul screams that it was The Samurai who made him do it. But The Samurai reminds him that Paul was walking away from the outpost when he became possessed by hatred and anger. Tamura didn't even fight for his life. Even if he had been left alone, he would have certainly died from starvation and illnesses. Paul dares not look back at what he has done to the Japanese sergeant. He gazes at his own reflection on a murky puddle, it is that of his **77 years old self**. He notices The Samurai bears no reflection. Trembling, Paul asks if he is the Devil. Smiling, The Samurai remarks that to believe in the Devil is to also believe in God, which conflicts with Paul's agnosticism. Paul blames The Samurai for tempting him into murdering Tamura but no, that was solely his doing. His shadow pushed him to do it and his shadow is intrinsically part of himself. It's the beast in him.

The Samurai reveals people of his time would have called him an *Obake*, a spirit in Japanese folklore, but his true origins are somehow more enigmatic and complex. He claims he is merely an observer and has no relation to any deities, demons, or religions. His goal is to seek knowledge and understanding. And from observing Paul's recent actions, he knows Tamura was just a scapegoat to Paul's frustrations at himself: his rage, failures and his own helplessness in this war. He compensates his inferiority and guilt through aggression. Someone had to pay for his mistakes and he picked Tamura to displace his self-loathing. The Samurai reassures Paul that since this is war, Paul will face no consequences for killing Harper and Tamura. With Tamura, he committed moral evil, the most obvious form of evil, and his conscience will never let him forget what he has done. Before departing, he asks Paul one final question, "Do you now remember who I am?" Alone once more, these words echo in Paul's mind and a distant and fragmented memory from his adolescence creeps back into his thoughts...

When Paul rejoins his squadron from where he last left them, he is met with a most horrifying sight. They are all dead. Not from bullets or mortar blasts but by a blade. Sergeant Wallace's corpse lies half-submerged in the mud, his genitals having been hacked off and shoved into his mouth, suffocating him even in death. As he stands over Wallace's grotesquely mutilated body, his lips twitch into a small and quiet smile.

In 1984, in a hospital room, a 77 years old Paul spends his final days on his deathbed, having lost his battle to lung cancer. Standing by his side are his son Joseph, 37 years old, and his grandson Thomas, 17 years old. Although he is fully conscious and able to speak, he is feeble and cannot walk. He is also in denial that he is about to die anytime now and insists that he has been feeling better lately, a clear sign of terminal lucidity. After recounting his son and grandson his time during the Pacific War, Paul ponders on the inescapable persistence of the past, the feelings of grief, guilt and self-hatred that inhabit his mind even at death's door. Most overwhelming of all is his fear that the "beast" in him will be passed on to his descendants. He begs them to never succumb to it, whatever challenges they may face. He particularly relates to the concept of "**ressentiment**"

from Nietzsche, a defence mechanism used to project one's own inferiority and flaws to an external scapegoat, such as Sergeant Tamura.

He posits that the id conceals the evil within us and admits to joining the Army not because of his patriotism or to obtain retribution for Pearl Harbor but to channel his wicked impulses and desires through sublimation, into somewhere where they'd be accepted. His "beast" wasn't created in the war, the war simply unleashed it. He says this evil in him once got him really close to the Devil. Joseph, shocked to hear these revelations, reminds Paul that he is an atheist to which Paul replies, "God might be dead but the Devil survives in all of us."

He disparages the outdated and dogmatic concepts of good and evil taught by religious institutions that lead to herd mentality. For religious people, Paul believes their sense of morality is determined not through self-awareness but through the fear of divine retaliation and the promise of heaven after death. He believes true evil has no face and no shape but it's omnipresent. Just then, Paul describes a **snake** at a corner of the room. He seems to be the only one to notice it but the sight of the reptile considerably troubles him. Again lost in his recollections, he speaks of another kind of evil unrelated to human morality: nature's evil.

Part 2 - Trinity

For this part, Paul, 17 years old, is portrayed by the same actor who plays his grandson, Thomas, in the frame narrative.

In late 1924 in Minnesota, a smallpox epidemic originating from the Twin Cities plagues a small town amidst a harsh freezing winter. One afternoon, Paul toils through thick layers of snow towards his girlfriend's house. An eerie silence reigns in his surroundings. Everyone remains isolated in their home, fearing contamination. Paul looks despondent, tormented by his father's drunken outbursts and his mother's worsening condition from the virus. His sole source of solace is his girlfriend, Anna.

At her doorsteps, he is met with a warm embrace. She inquires about his mother and Paul admits it's unlikely she'll recover. With Anna's father still at work, they are all alone in the house but even in her presence, his words seem oddly cold and emotionless, as if he has always known his mother was fated to die from the disease. Paul's sorrows are now buried deeply in his mind, overpowered by a numb resignation to whatever fate has already decided. Anna reassures him that she is fine with him opening up to her but he retorts that this won't change the seemingly fatalistic nature of his life. From the moment his mother was infected, he somehow knew she wouldn't survive. Similarly, she suffered years of abuse at the hands of his father but Paul knew she would never leave or challenge him, just like he knew his father would never change. The powerlessness to deal with these situations induced in Paul a feeling that everything he experienced seemed predetermined. To counter fatalism, Paul believes suicide would be the ultimate expression of free-will. He also refers to Nietzsche's quote, "The thought of suicide is a great consolation", to justify why he often thinks about killing himself.

Anna confesses how she also struggled with suicidal thoughts after her mother's death in a chemical plant accident. But she realized she had to live for her father, who would be all alone without her. Anna cares deeply for him and the thought of what leaving this world would do to him has dissuaded her from committing the

irrevocable. Her father lives to take care of her and see her flourish. Similarly, she lives to make him proud. Without each other, they'd have no reason to keep on going. Paul ignores Anna's words, too blinded by his self-pity, and reaffirms his hatred for his dad, claiming that without his mother, he would have no reason to live. Looking straight into his eyes, Anna, in a soft voice, simply says, "Then live for me." Before he can respond, she kisses him passionately. In the heat of the moment, they undress each other and make love for the first time. After climaxing, Paul rests his head on her bare chest and finally succumbs to his emotions. Anna gently strokes his back as tears slip out of his eyes, silent and uncontrollable.

In the evening, Paul returns home where his father is already drunk, staggering aimlessly in the kitchen. Slurring, he asks Paul to join him for dinner, which he categorically refuses. But he insists and Paul, not wanting to get on his nerves, quietly sits down at the table. While eating, the uncomfortable silence and the tension between the two becomes unbearable. Paul's father begs his son to stop hating him, saying he never raised a hand against Paul, always put food on the table, and always provided for him. Paul knows this is all true, he was never physically abusive towards Paul. All his outbursts happened while he was by himself, screaming at whatever gloom and despair entered his thoughts, or directed towards his wife. But to Paul, that made no difference. All the pain and suffering his mother endured because of him remains inexcusable. The conversation stalls and his father momentarily leaves the table. He returns with a pistol picked from a drawer in his bedroom. He unhesitantly presses the barrel on his own temple, much to Paul's dismay. He tells his son, calmly but sternly, that if things don't change and if they continue living as strangers in the same house, he will kill himself. Deeply disturbed, Paul reassures him that he will be there for him from now on before quietly retreating to his bedroom, knowing very well he meant none of it.

On the next morning, Paul attends a morning service in the town's church with his best friend, Harper. Harper senses Paul's distress and invites him for dinner at his place, saying his parents would be glad to have him. But Paul refuses, knowing his father would never approve, especially after what happened last night. Knowing Paul's hardships, Harper implores him to keep his strengths through faith. He knows about Paul's suicidal ideation and reminds him that taking one's life is a sin. Paul, having been raised a Christian by his mother, appreciates the comfort offered by religion but right now, Harper's preachiness is particularly grating.

As the attendees leave the church, Paul lingers behind to admire a replica of *Trinity* by Andrei Rublev hung on a wall. The priest has noticed the reverence Paul has for this painting, having occasionally seen him being awestruck by it. The priest approaches him and explains how the painting originally meant to depict the three angels who visited Abraham at the Oak of Mamre, as told in the Book of Genesis. However, over time, many have interpreted it as the Holy Trinity (The Father, the Son and the Holy Ghost). Together, they embody peace, unity and love. In the painting, Paul sees what his family could have been but instead, they are the complete opposite of everything the painting represents. He updates the priest on his mother's deteriorating health and his father's continuous descent into alcoholism. Despite his prayers, his devotion to the Church, going to confession and services and basically living an exemplary Christian life, everything keeps getting worse. He questions God's supposed omnibenevolence and whether he listens to his prayers. His inaction and silence accentuates Paul's spiritual crisis. The priest affirms it's normal to question one's faith in times of adversity but

reminds him that mortality is a natural aspect of life and God will not intervene if it's all part of his plans. Their role as Christians is not to understand but to trust God's plan, which may currently be beyond human understanding. Paul nods, letting the words settle within him, but it's clear he isn't convinced.

Paul's next stop is the hospital ward. The place is crowded with a myriad of nurses and doctors moving around with urgency, each of them playing a role in the fight against the smallpox outbreak. Paul approaches his mother's room, where she's quarantined behind a closed door. Since he cannot go in, he looks at her through a small glass window but something greatly unsettles him. His mother's face is so covered in pustules and rashes, it barely even resembles a face.

In 1984, a wave of absolute anguish crashes into Paul as he screams, "I can't remember her face! I can't! Why can't I remember her face?!" Joseph and Thomas exchange a confused glance. After a long, aching pause, he regains his composure and resumes his recollections.

Back to 1924, a deeply disturbed Paul traipses out of the hospital, the image of his mother's ravaged face seared into his mind. He heads back to Anna's place for some much needed comfort. But once there, what he sees fractures his reality:

Instead of a house, he sees a construction site. Where her normal wooden house was, we now see scaffolds, cement bags and a sign stating that a grocery store is under construction. He scans his surroundings; he is definitely at the right address. As for Anna, there are absolutely no signs of her. How could this be possible? Her house was just there the day before. There's no way it got demolished and a construction site was set up over just one night. It didn't make sense. The only person he lived for is now gone. Dejected, he breaks down in tears in front of dozens of understandably confused construction workers.

At nightfall, his father isn't back home yet. There's a power cut and Paul lights up a few candles around the house. Taking advantage of the solitude, he slips into his father's bedroom, rummaging through the drawers until he finds the pistol. Alongside it are some rum bottles and he unhesitantly grabs one of them. He locks himself in the bedroom and fidgets around with the gun. He shoves the barrel into his mouth, with his finger placed on the trigger. But he can't quite do it yet. Thankfully, the alcohol is here to facilitate the act. He yanks out the cork and begins drinking profusely. The rum burns his throat but he doesn't care.

Suddenly, a tumultuous thundersnow erupts outside. The candle lights flicker, some of them go off. The wind lets off a shivering howl and a spooky atmosphere builds up. Drunk, Paul spins the gun on the table and the barrel ends its spin pointing at a corner where Paul, eyes wide open, encounters a most spine-chilling sight: He finds a **Spectre**, clothed in a ripped up white cloak with only a patch of darkness where a face would be. Paul is, however, more terrified of the implications of the ghost's presence. Could it be his mother? Does it mean she died tonight?

The Spectre, with a deep and gravelly voice, quickly dismisses his concerns. He claims to be just a wanderer, having spent a long time on this world, more than he initially anticipated. From the bedroom mirror, Pauls sees that The Spectre has no reflection and projects no shadow. More disturbingly, his own reflection is that of his

77-year-old self. Voice cracking, Paul asks if he is a ghost to which The Spectre replies, "What is a ghost to you?" Hands shaking, Pauls tries to answer by saying a ghost could be a lost soul who still has unfinished businesses in the material world. Since they keep clinging to their past life, they are unable to leave.

For The Spectre, however, ghosts are memories who do not choose to remain here. Feelings associated with these memories (such as sadness, sorrow, guilt and longing) strengthen their ties to our world, preventing them from leaving. To free them, the living has to let go of these feelings. When asked how, The Spectre speaks of rejecting the subjective nature of memories and accepting reality as it truly is. Recollections are often obscured by personal feelings which evolve over time. Each memory, good or bad, is often exaggerated to the point that they become detached from the truth, shaped by the emotions we attach to them. Worse of all are those who choose to ignore certain memories due to the feelings they may evoke, something The Spectre claims Paul is doing. These feelings are still present in Paul but he isn't aware of them.

Paul isn't convinced; his issues don't stem from memories. They come from the constant loneliness, abandonment and the relentless ways his deepest fears have taken shape before his eyes. He wants it all to end and the idea that a single bullet can put an end to his misery is greatly tempting. He lashes out, claiming his father is responsible for his mother's illness, something which sounds irrational to The Spectre. Paul believes there's a "beast" in his father but The Spectre affirms everyone carries such a beast. The Spectre argues that Paul's anguish is also being subconsciously exacerbated by a repressed memory. Unless he confronts it and accepts that it truly happened, he will never find peace. Deep inside, Paul knows what The Spectre is referring to. He tries to retrieve the memory but he knows very well it's going to be an agonizing endeavour:

In 1914, a 7 years old Paul enters the kitchen. His father, emotionless, leaves the room with bloodied knuckles. Confused and afraid, Paul approaches his mother, lying on the floor with blood streaming down her face. She's barely able to move. He asks her if he should call for somebody but she refuses. Coughing and whispering shakily, she begs Paul to never speak a word of what just happened. Just then, the father returns and Paul stays silent out of sheer terror. He asks Paul to look at his mother straight in the eyes and say that he hates her. Paul refuses but the man insists. The mother looks at Paul with teary eyes and tells him it's okay if he says it. "I hate you," Pauls forces out, tears running down his cheeks while his father pats his head proudly.

Back in 1924, the recovered memory sends Paul into a confused and disoriented state. He has to numb the pain somehow and thus drinks more and more. By now, The Spectre is gone. When the storm finally subsides, his father returns and calls for his son to join him for dinner. A drunk Paul staggers to the kitchen, with the pistol in one hand. On seeing him, the father freezes, his expression flashing with an unmistakable sense of terror. Before he even has the time to utter a single word, Paul smashes his nose with the pistol's butt and violently thumps his father's face again and again until it becomes a bloody mess. Paul warns him that if he ever speaks to him again, he will put a bullet straight through his skull.

In 1984, the elderly Paul blames fate for his cancer and confesses his resentment at those who will live when he dies. He is bitterly jealous that they will get to experience things he never had the chance to experience, such as a long-lasting and meaningful romantic relationship. Joseph, shaken by his words, cautiously asks if Paul ever truly

loved his wife, Helen. After a lengthy pause, he finally admits that he settled for her solely to give him a reason to live and to attenuate his loneliness. A disturbed Joseph presses further and asks if he even loves him or Thomas. Paul reassures him that he does since they carry a part of him. They are his blood, his legacy and the only parts of himself which he doesn't regret. He wants to see them succeed and live a great life to compensate for his own wretched existence.

He then admits the only time he ever fell in love was with Anna. Joseph doesn't recall Paul ever mentioning someone by that name. He explains that after losing his virginity to her back in 1924, he never saw her again. For him, the lack of closure was deeply unsettling. On the same day she vanished, his mother died that night. He laments on how fate brings people together only to cruelty tear them apart. Paul grabs Joseph's hand and thanks him for being by his side, restating how much he hated his father, who died alone and miserable. He hopes Joseph doesn't hate him, admitting he himself wasn't a perfect dad. He breaks down in tears while Joseph and Thomas look at each other, unsure of what to say.

Joseph mentions how his brother, David, couldn't make it today, tied up with work commitments. Paul understands but reiterates his wish to see both of his sons one last time before the end comes. He then drifts into bargaining with the idea of death, saying if God really exists, now would be time to prove it by saving him. He goes on a spiral where he reflects on how different life choices, such as decades of chain-smoking and postponing his cancer treatment, could have saved him. He finally admits his soul isn't ready to leave this world, he feels he still has much to experience in spite of his old age. He regrets never having the chance to wish his mother farewell and despairs over how unrecognizable she had become in her last days, to the point that her face, completely covered in bumps and rashes, is all he can remember of her appearance. He now understands she was a victim of nature's evil and not his father, whom he had irrationally blamed for her illness. However, Paul reveals there's still one last type of evil, something invisible and less obvious: the evil of chance, aka **metaphysical evil**.

Part 3 - Odio Fati

For this segment, the 57 years old Paul is played by the same actor who plays the 77 years old Paul in the frame narrative, without the old age makeup.

On an otherwise uneventful afternoon in 1964, a random short-circuit triggers a fire in an ammonium nitrate storage facility at a fertilizer production plant. Despite attempts to quench the fire, it is too late. Once it reaches the stockpiles, a tremendous explosion blasts through the building, burning and injuring hundreds of workers.

In a nearby hospital, Paul hastily runs down the corridor, accompanied by a 17 years old Joseph and 9 years old David. They all look agitated and overwrought with dread. In the waiting room outside the ICU, Helen's father updates Paul on her condition. Helen has been severely burned from the explosion and it's presently unknown if she will survive her injuries. Paul explodes in anger, blaming the fertilizer company for the tragedy, saying how Helen always had concerns about regulations being occasionally overlooked.

The intensivist arrives and apologizes for being the bearer of bad news: Helen suffered third degree burns all over her body rendering skin grafting impossible. Her legs were badly damaged so the doctors had to perform a

bilateral amputation. She's currently under high doses of morphine and antibiotics to stop the infections but considering the nature of her burns, that might not last long. The only way to know if she will make it is to wait. As of now, only one visitor can be allowed into the ICU and Helen's father insists Paul goes in. However, the intensivist warns him that although Helen recently regained consciousness, her vocal cords were damaged so she won't be able to speak.

In the ICU, a heavy bandage covers Helen's face. Both her legs are missing and she remains completely still, having been medically numbed from the pain. If it wasn't for the cardiac monitor, one would think she's already dead. Paul approaches her bed but he can't get too close. Tears well up in his eyes as he starts apologizing vehemently for being a bad husband. He vaguely admits to "messing up" throughout their marriage and begs her not to die so that he can make up for his mistakes. He promises she won't let her die and reassures her that he'll take good care of their sons whilst she recovers.

A few hours into the night, the family anxiously awaits any updates on Helen's condition, hoping for any sign of improvement. The intensivist approaches them and through his eyes, Paul can already infer what he's about to say: his wife is gone. Paul dashes outside for a much needed breath of fresh air, unconcerned about how this news is affecting his children. He pulls a hip flask from his coat and empties it, desperately trying to numb his distress, before lighting up a cigarette.

Out in the darkness of the street, faintly lit by dim lamp posts, he discerns a strange figure approaching him. He's a tall and heavily deformed man, oddly dressed in a business suit. Relative to his body, the man's head is exceedingly large. He walks with a cane and stops next to Paul while also lighting up a cigarette. He introduces himself as **Proteus**, not named after the god but after the syndrome afflicting him.

They strike up a conversation and Paul reveals how his wife just died. Proteus, emphasizing with Paul's grief and anger, speaks of *Amor fati*, Latin for "love of fate", as the only concept that helps him appreciate and enjoy life despite all its hardships. He talks about his struggles to breathe normally, his inability to move without pain and how sleeping in the wrong position could easily suffocate him to death. Then, he reflects on how scared and repulsed people are of him, making any form of relationship unachievable. He ponders on the mysterious ways of God, calling them too puzzling and deterministic. Remembering the **paradox of free will**, he wonders what it means for us, humans. If God is supposedly omniscient, as described by Christianity, then how do humans have choice? To exemplify this, he says if God knows someone will choose evil, then that person is compelled to choose evil since choosing the righteous path would nullify God's supposed omniscience.

Having been religious before, all the unanswered questions married to this paradox are making Paul's agnosticism converge into full-blown atheism. Nothing in his life could validate any kind of faith. Proteus still thinks faith is important though fragile. He suggests many have preserved their morality or humanity through the belief of heaven and hell. Regardless of what he, himself, believes in, he argues **Pascal's wager** is a logical argument to justify one's belief in the divine. Even if God's existence cannot be proven, being religious will grant someone eternity in heaven while a non-believer would spend eternity in hell if God happens to truly exist. Paul

affirms that he wants to believe but sooner than later, he feels he will become inevitably convinced there's no God.

Proteus cryptically reveals that there is an ultimate test Paul should take to convince himself of the existence of the divine and prove his faith if it ever rekindles. He points his cane towards the far end of the street, which is unilluminated and fully submerged in darkness. At the end of the street, Paul will reunite with his wife. Paul laughs it off but Proteus gives him a jewel box, known as a *tamatebako*, which was gifted to him by a man dressed in samurai armor during a visit on Bougainville Island. Paul freezes, suddenly remembering his encounter with The Samurai. Proteus proposes that perhaps Paul's faith never went away, it just got buried too deeply inside him and it's time to reawaken it. Burning with questions, Paul asks how this will prove his faith and Proteus tells him that as long as he never opens the box, everything will be fine till the day he dies. He wishes Paul good luck before vanishing back into the darkness. Drunk and desperate, Paul undertakes his walk along the street, having nothing much to lose at this point. And as promised by Proteus, Paul does find Helen, unscattered and in perfect health. They share a tearful embrace as Paul promises to always love and cherish her.

Two decades later in a retirement home, an elderly Paul and Helen spend most of their days peacefully resting and playing board games. One day, Joseph and David, now grown men, and a teenage Thomas visit them, having brought Paul's and Helen's belongings from their old house which the family will soon be selling. Joseph and David share a close and affectionate relationship with Paul, contrasting Paul's absolute hatred for his father. As the night falls, the children hug their parents goodbye, leaving them to unpack their belongings.

Among the boxes, Paul finds the *tamatebako*. In the corner of the room, a snake slithers silently, but Paul takes no heed to it. Failing to remember Proteus' words, he opens the box out of curiosity. A white smoke swirls out of it and envelopes Helen. Almost instantaneously, burn scars horrifyingly materialize all over her body, causing a prompt but agonizing death. Struck by sheer terror and confusion, Paul's world fractures around him and he is transported back to the night Helen died in 1964 where he is 57 years old again.

On that same street in front of the hospital, Proteus reappears and recounts his findings from observing Paul throughout the years: He never had faith and only prayed when he wanted something from God. He once believed in the divine solely for comfort and reassurance but his beliefs were never genuine. Faith wasn't buried in him, it was never there to begin with. What was hidden all along was the absence of faith, along with the "beast" residing in the fabrics of his unconscious. Shaking and broken, Paul asks what was in the box. Proteus chillingly replies, "Her death." Paul gazes into the rainwater of a shallow pothole and as before, Proteus produces no reflection and Paul's reflection is that of his 77-year-old self. Proteus morphs into The Spectre, The Samurai and then back to Proteus before dissolving into nothingness. They were, after all, the same entity.

Back to 1984, Paul reflects on how the night of Helen's death marked his descent into atheism and existential nihilism. He lived under the belief that since life had no inherent meaning, nothing he did truly mattered. But now, as the end is nigh, he recalls **Albert Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus*** and realizes that instead of succumbing to nihilism, he should have embraced the meaninglessness and recognized the absurdity of life not as a curse, but as a freedom. And instead of hating fate, he should have accepted it. Even though

meaning-making and meaning-seeking didn't work out for him, he now sees he could have treated his guilt, his loneliness and all his pain as opportunities to become better.

Through all his recollections, he had hoped to achieve ego integrity, coming to terms with both his life and inevitable death. But all he found was pain and regret. He realizes his lifelong obsession with death was misguided for death is meaningless and inescapable. He should have focused on the choices he made while still alive, on how he lived rather than how he would die. After a moment of self-realization, he realizes he has not found ego integrity. All he found was its opposite: despair.

A curious Thomas asks about what the entity really was. Paul doesn't have any clear answers. For much of his life, he thought it was the Devil himself, especially given its use of temptation and oddly convenient timing. But now, he admits he will probably never know for certain. Just then, Paul's eyes drift to the corner of the hospital room, where the snake is, with its unblinking eyes fixed on him. A chill runs down his spine but he says nothing to Joseph and Thomas, knowing he is the only one who can see the reptile.

Joseph appears visibly agitated, as if he's been holding back things to say but can't bring himself to do so, at least not yet. He asks Thomas to step outside with him and once alone, he confides Paul was never actually at the hospital the night Helen died. He was too drunk and passed out. It was their uncle who brought him and David to say goodbye to their mother. Joseph believes Paul is delusional and desperate for closure, claiming much of his recollections seem grossly distorted and possibly entirely fabricated. He asks Thomas to wait for him outside whilst he has a chat with his father, alone.

Joseph steps back into the room and locks the door, his mind overwhelmed with rage that has been simmering for years now. He is a time bomb waiting to explode. With voice raising, he lashes out at Paul for warping his memories to suit his narrative, burying the ugly truths under self-pity and fantasy. Of all the regrets Paul has spilled out over the past hours, Joseph points out that not once did he explicitly regret being a terrible father to him and David. Joseph's outburst comes as a bolt out of the blue for Paul, eyes wide with confusion, unable to comprehend what his son is talking about. Joseph carries on by describing how much he hates Paul, calling him self-centered, aggressive, narcissistic, and a man who spent his life drowning in his own sorrow while ignoring the damage he caused around him. Joseph swore he'd never become like his father, but when that's all he ever knew, it became impossible to recognize who he even was anymore. Even Paul's alcoholism and volatility became part of Joseph as he grew older.

Paul refuses to accept responsibility, pleading with Joseph not to blame him for his own shortcomings. But Joseph fires back that all Paul has ever done was blame his actions on the entity he conjured up to justify how terrible of a person he is. As the tension escalates, the snake in the room hisses violently but only Paul can hear it. The sound it makes, merged with Joseph's words, reawakens the truth to Paul: the entity was merely reflective and observant. Paul's actions, murdering Tamura, beating up his father and abandoning his faith, were all choices he made.

Joseph reiterates a previous question on whether he ever cared for anyone but himself, saying how after Paul became convinced nothing mattered, he was free to do as he pleases, mistreating and neglecting his children in the process. He then reveals the truth about David's absence; he couldn't care less about Paul. Joseph is only here to keep up appearances by being with his father's side during his final days and to expound what he has kept in his heart for far too long.

Pauls sobs uncontrollably. He tries to convince Joseph that he has changed, that he's no longer the man he once was and that age and regret have reshaped him. But his son can no longer believe a word coming out of his mouth. Paul cries out that he never wanted his children to inherit the worst parts of him, especially fearing how the "beast" in one can spread to their descendants through the "collective unconscious".

Paul's voice trembles as he confesses his fear for the **eternal return** and how the traumas and evils of life are destined to repeat across eternity. He dreads the thought that after death, he will relive his life again and again, succumbing to the same mistakes and experiencing the same woes. He desperately hopes this isn't what awaits him and that he will finally find peace. Joseph, unmoved, simply replies, "You'll find out soon enough."

Paul, his voice now faint and weary, finally concludes by accepting his life was an ordeal, marked by suffering and missteps. He admits that instead of learning from his father's failures, he perpetuated them through Joseph and David, continuing the very cycle he sought to break. Though his life is full of regrets, he is grateful that they have finally brought him a sliver of self-awareness, even if it's too late to do anything about it. Now on the verge of death, he is unsure of what to believe about God and the afterlife. Part of him welcomes death to put him out of his misery. Life on Earth has already been hell so if hell does exist, he doubts it could be any worse. After finally acknowledging the damage he has done as a father, he begs Joseph for forgiveness.

Though surprised that Paul has recognized his faults, it's too late for redemption. As his final words to his father, Joseph confesses he will never be able to forgive him. "I just can't," he utters as he makes his way towards the door. Instead of letting the dejection take hold, Paul responds with a simple and understanding nod, having come to terms with the consequences of the life he lived. Just as Joseph unlocks the door to leave, he turns to the corner of the room and he sees it. He sees it very well. The sight of the snake frightens him but he remains silent, choosing to ignore its presence. The door closes back and Paul is left alone with the snake, awaiting certain death.

Epilogue

In the funeral home, Thomas, the brothers Joseph and David, and their respective wives stand before Paul's casket. As expected, the brothers aren't very saddened by their father's passing. David's sole concern is whether Paul left them a worthwhile inheritance. When David casually asks what was Joseph's last conversation with their father, Joseph simply replies, "Nothing much." There is a subtle sense of remorse in his voice but it's clear he has no intention of ever revisiting what was said. Contrastingly, David exhibits no regrets for not being by his father's side in his last moments.

Late at night, with everyone gone and only Paul's closed coffin remaining, a strange stillness settles over the room. The place is faintly lit and strangely enough, the snake is there. It hisses one last time before slithering out of the room through the narrow gap beneath the front doors. Paul's corpse lies inside the closed coffin, seemingly at peace. After a long stretch of silence, a strange noise begins to stir from inside the coffin. Right then, Paul bursts out of the coffin, gasping for breath, drenched in sweat and eyes wide in absolute shock and bewilderment. In a moment that defies all logic, Paul has returned from the dead...

The End